

ENGLISH 204: INTERDISCIPLINARY READING, WRITING AND RESEARCH
PATTEN UNIVERSITY AT SAN QUENTIN
FALL SEMESTER 2014

Class Meetings

Fridays	6:00-8:00pm (Lauren)
Sundays	3:00-5:00pm (Adriane)

Note: There will be no class on Friday, November 28th.

Instructors

Adriane Fresh: PhD Candidate, Department of Political Science, Stanford University
Lauren Baker: Master's in Linguistics, Master's in Public Health (MPH)

Research Assistants

John Cook
Rebecca Kling
Sonja Tonnesen

Course Overview

"Archaeology is the search for fact, not truth. If it's truth you're looking for, Dr. Tyree's philosophy class is right down the ball."

-- Indiana Jones, *The Last Crusade*

English 204 is designed to be an introduction to the process and problems of research, broadly defined, while simultaneously improving students' critical reading, critical thinking and writing skills in preparation for more advanced coursework. The course examines research in both theory and practice -- from what it means to search for *fact* (or *truth*) across different disciplines -- to the methods that researchers employ in their work. Our readings will focus on completed works of academic research, texts about the research process, as well as texts that allow us to improve our written communication skills. Through these readings and a series of guest presentations by practicing researchers in a variety of fields, we'll ask ourselves what questions interest researchers in different disciplines, what problems or concerns arise in their research, and how they and their discipline search for fact, or truth. How, in essence, do they go about knowing what they know?

In addition to reading and reflecting critically on the research of others, students will gain an understanding of the research process through practice of their own in pursuit of the course's principal goal: a final research project. The research project will be individually directed work in the student's area of greatest interest, and will be communicated in the form of both a formal academic essay, and an oral presentation to the members of the intellectual community created by the class. Because this formal academic essay represents a substantial amount of work, the primary tasks of the course are a series of small assignments that guide the student through the process: from posing a complex research question and developing an argument in response to that question, to outlining the paper, and evaluating sources in an annotated bibliography. Students also take their final written paper through a revision process to practice editing and incorporating constructive feedback.

Important Dates

The add/drop deadline is **Wednesday, September 17th**.

The withdrawal deadline is **Wednesday, November 19th**.

If you have any hesitations or concerns about whether this course is right for you, please keep these dates in mind, and don't wait until the last moment to have a discussion with your instructors or PUP staff about how to proceed.

Course and Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to

1. describe and differentiate research as concept and practice; including how practice differs across academic disciplines, specifically regarding the questions and methods researchers employ.
2. understand and analyze the academic research of others by: identifying key components, particularly those relevant to students' own research projects; evaluating those components; and summarizing, paraphrasing and quoting components for use in students' own research.
3. construct and support a logical argument by writing a clear thesis statement, organizing subsidiary claims, and assembling appropriate evidence in support of those claims.
4. produce sentences that are not only grammatically correct, but also focus on active verbs, clear subjects and varied length and structure; and organize those sentences in logically progressing paragraphs that focus on a main idea.
5. verbally communicate their ideas about their own research and the research of others both formally and informally through the exchange of ideas in class-discussion and through the preparation and production of in-class presentations.

Course Requirements

The following represent the course requirements and the percentage of your final grade that each represents:

Participation.	15%
Short Essays.	
Short Essay 1	5%
Short Essay 2	10%
Preparatory Assignments for Final Paper.	
Project Proposal	5%
Paper Outline	5%
Annotated Bibliography	5%
Rough Draft	10%
Final Paper.	30%
Final Presentation.	15%

Grading

Grades will be based on the following translation between letter and number grades:

A+	=	96.3%+	C+	=	76.6-80.0%
A	=	93.3-96.6%	C	=	73.3-76.6%
A-	=	90.0-93.3%	C-	=	70.0-73.3%
B+	=	86.6-90.0%	D+	=	66.6-70.0%
B	=	83.3-86.6%	D	=	63.3-66.6%
B-	=	80.0-83.3%	D-	=	60.0-63.3%

Below a C- (70%) is considered a failing grade for the purposes of this class.

Assignments

Students should submit all assignments with their **(1) their first *and* last name, (2) the date, and (3) the name of the assignment.** **Late work will not be accepted** except in very special circumstances. Should there be institution-wide lockdowns, note that assignments (and classes) will be shifted. In that event, keep track of the *class number* for which assignments are due, rather than the date.

The following describes briefly the assignments that you will complete for this course. Note that these descriptions are merely a brief overview of each assignment. When you are given the assignment, you will have additional information about expectations and how your assignment will be evaluated, as well as the opportunity to ask questions.

Short Essay 1. Asking Questions. Due Week 2, Class 3 -- Friday, September 12th.

This assignment is designed to encourage your curiosity, thoughtfulness, and encourage you to question the world around you. To complete this assignment, you'll take an object, or idea from around you -- the object can be as simple and tangible as a tube of toothpaste, or as complex and intangible as the idea of friendship -- and ask questions about every aspect of that object or idea. The questions need not have answers, and the questions may range far and wide if questioning your object/idea leads you to ask questions about other objects/ideas and so on. Though the essay will primarily consist of questions, you should still take care with how you choose to organize your essay to ensure that the essay is engaging for your reader. Strong essays will be well-organized, exhibit proper grammar, and will demonstrate thoughtfulness and creativity in the questions asked.

Preliminary Topic for Initial Research Articles. Due Week 3, Class 5 -- Friday, September 19th.

This is an *un-graded* assignment that is nevertheless your first step in receiving research materials to help you draft your research project proposal. Because a some general background information on one's topic is oftentimes crucial to being able to narrow a topic and formulate a research proposal, in this assignment you'll prove your research assistant some idea of what your topic is so that they can pull some initial background reading for you.

Short Essay 2. Critical Analysis. Due Week 3, Class 6 -- Sunday, September 21st.

This course asks students to reflect critically on the research of others as well as build skills that allow students to engage with academic works... In this assignment you will read a seminal article in psychology, Stanley Milgrom's 1965 work entitled "Some Conditions of Obedience and Disobedience of Authority," and reflect critically on the researchers question, method, and findings. After summarizing for a reader unfamiliar with the work what the article says, you'll move on to addressing the following questions -- what is the researchers question? broadly, narrowly? what argument does the article make in answer to that question? what method does the article employ? what evidence is brought to bear on the research question? what are the findings? how does the author motivate the research, that is, answer the question *so what?* Strong essays show a thorough understanding of the article, and balance facts of the research, with the student's own reflections upon that research.

Project Proposal. Due Week 5, Class 10 -- Sunday, October 5th.

The final paper will be broken down into a series of smaller assignments completed throughout the quarter to ensure that the paper is a manageable task. Your first assignment related to the final paper is your project proposal. In 1-2 pages, introduce your reader to the topic you plan to research, what your research question is (if there is a broad and a narrow research question, introduce both of them). Explain to your reader why this question is interesting or meaningful (think of your answer to the question: *so what?*). Utilize your initial background reading in the drafting of your proposal if it's relevant. Strong project proposals will ask a *research* question that is feasibly addressed in the scope of the class.

Annotated Bibliography. Due Week 8, Class 14 -- Friday, October 24th.

Understanding, using and citing research articles in the service of answering your own research question is a key component of this class. This assignment asks you to write an annotated bibliography of the source material you're using in your final paper. Your bibliography should include proper citation style (either MLA or Chicago) for each of the sources you are using, with citations ordered alphabetically. Then, for each source, you should include a very brief summary -- just 1-3 sentences -- of the main points of the article.

Paper Outline. Due Week 9, Class 18 -- Sunday, November 2nd.

To help you organize your final paper, you'll be submitting a preliminary outline. Your outline should include your research question, thesis statement and sketch out your supporting claims, including which evidence, and sources you're using to support each claim. Your outline should communicate clearly how you're logically structuring your paper's overall argument, and what counterclaims you plan to address. Strong outlines will provide a full sketch of the paper's logical structure including a clear understanding of claims and evidence and how they relate to your thesis statement.

Rough Draft of Final Paper. Due Week 10, Class 19 -- Friday, November 7th.

The rough draft offers students the opportunity to make significant progress on their final paper and receive constructive feedback in the process. Please refer to the description of the Final Draft below to understand expectations.

Final Draft of Final Paper. Due Week 13, Class 26 -- Sunday, November 30th.

The semester culminates with the final draft of your final project paper. This research paper is an academic research paper that asks a research question, makes an argument in answer to that question, and supports that argument with logical claims and evidence culled from quality sources. The paper demonstrates the student's expertise in the area of research, as well as a strong grasp of grammar and style. The sources used in the paper are properly cited using an in-text or footnote/endnote citation style, and the paper is accompanied by a well-formatted bibliography that demonstrates proper attribution of all source material.

Final Oral Presentation. Due Week 12, Classes 23 and 24.

Communicating your ideas orally is oftentimes as important as communicating through writing. Your final assignment for the class will be to share the research you conducted during the semester with the intellectual community formed by our class. Strong presentations will translate the content of the paper into the different format that is presenting orally, paying particular attention to organization and structure -- having a compelling introductory hook and a meaningful conclusion that answers the question of *so what* for the audience. Furthermore, strong presentations will be well-rehearsed, but not read directly from notes.

What is class participation?

Participation means coming to class prepared every day, having completed any required readings and assignments listed for that day of class. Participation involves paying attention during to both the instructor and your fellow students. Participation entails offering your thoughts, answering questions, and posing new ones, yet it also means being respectful of the fact that our class comprises many students with diverse opinions, and offering time and intellectual space to for others to participate. Engaged, respectful and

thoughtful listening, therefore, comprises a crucial component of participation. In general, high quality participation is based on the quality of your contributions to class, not the quantity.

Methods of Instruction

This class will employ a variety of instructional methods, however the majority of classes will be instructed as seminar-style discussions. Therefore, student participation will be key in creating a successful learning environment. Other classes may be instructed as mini lectures, while group work, oral presentations, and in-class writing and revision will also occur.

Attendance

Students must arrive on time for all classes, and ***may not leave early***. The only excuse for tardiness is an institutional constraint beyond the student's control. Absences due to the following will be considered excused:

- Institutional lockdowns
- Medical lay-ins or hospitalizations
- Court dates
- Administrative segregation
- Religious holidays
- Package pick-up (one per semester)

It is PUP policy, however, that **no student who misses more than five classes, *even if the absences are excused*, will be able to pass the class**. Attendance will be taken at the beginning of every class. If an absence is excused, students need to submit the excuse in writing the of the next class following the absence. Students are responsible for catching up on material covered during classes they've missed, and for completing all assignments due or assigned on the day of the absence. Unexcused absences count against student participation and automatically drop students one third of a letter grade (for example, from a B+ to a B).

Plagiarism and Academic Integrity

The representation of another author's work as your own, whether that author is a fellow student, an author whose text you read or someone else entirely, constitutes plagiarism and is a violation of scholarly ethics and the honor code of the Prison University Project and Patten University. Plagiarism is in essence stealing, and is a serious offense. The consequences can be as severe as receiving a failing grade for an assignment, or for the course as a whole.

This class will teach you the proper use of source material and methods of attribution (citation styles) to ensure that you avoid plagiarism. We also encourage you to consult with study hall tutors and your instructors if you feel at all unsure about how to use a source.

Study Hall and Tutoring

We encourage you to attend study hall and take advantage of the tutoring services offered there. This course will demand a lot of your reading and writing skills. We expect that students will have a good grasp of proper grammar, sentence structure, and paragraph organization. If you feel that you have not mastered these writing and grammar skills yet, or if we point out that you could use further work on this front please make sure to attend study hall. For all students, study hall presents a great opportunity improve your writing and argumentation, and to get help reading from your source material, utilizing it in your paper, and properly summarizing, paraphrasing and quoting from it.

Course Readings

The required book for the course is the following:

Booth, Wayne C, Colomb, Gregory G, and Joseph M Williams (2003). The Craft of Research. 2nd Edition. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Other readings for the class will be handed out as photocopies when necessary.

Research Materials and Research Process

This course relies heavily on a team of research assistants (RAs) to find you the materials necessary for you to write your final essay and complete the assignments that build to that final goal. Each student will be assigned to work closely with one of the course's three research assistants. You'll have a chance to meet multiple time with your assigned RA over the course of the semester and share your topic and the progress of your project. Your RA will use their personal and institutional academic resources -- library, internet and otherwise -- to retrieve materials that will be useful to your project. Those materials will be printed by PUP staff, and distributed to you in-class (or occasionally in the mail). In order to ensure that you receive the materials most helpful to you, clear and thorough communication with your RA and your instructor will be key.

In addition to the research materials selected for you by your RA, the following are available to you:

PUP Library.

PUP has a great selection of books. Please request a list from us to see what's available. If you'd like to request a book, write the author and title and give it to one of your instructors. Books take approximately 1 week to reach students.

San Quentin Law Library.

Should your topic warrant, don't overlook the resources of the San Quentin Law Library.

COURSE SCHEDULE

All readings are listed on **the day for which they should be read.**

WEEK 1

1. Friday (September 5th) -- Introduction and Course Overview/What is Research?

In Class:

- Discussion of the course syllabus, objectives, themes, and requirements
- Personal introductions
- What is research?
- Truth and fact

Progress on Course Objectives: 1

2. Sunday (September 7th) -- Asking Questions

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 37-71.

In Class:

- Exercise: Questioning the world around us
- From research topic to research question
- Assign Short Essay 1

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

WEEK 2

3. Friday (September 12th) -- You and Your Reader

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 3-33.

In Class:

- Discussion of Short Essay 1
- Discussion of students' preliminary research topics
- Identifying your reader; writing for your reader
- Assign: Short Essay 2 Critical Analysis of an Academic Article
- **DUE: Short Essay 1 Asking Questions**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

4. Sunday (September 14th) -- Reading an Academic Article, Part I

**** Note: The Add/Drop Deadline is Wednesday, September 17th ****

In Class:

- Critical close-reading of an academic article (TBD) and group discussion
- Assign: Preliminary Topic for Initial Research Articles (un-graded assignment)

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2, 4

WEEK 3

5. Friday (September 19th) -- Evaluating Sources

In Class:

- Tentative: Meet the Research Assistants (Presentation: How we find your research materials)
- Discussion and exercise on types of sources and how to evaluate them
- Return Short Essay 1 graded
- **DUE: Preliminary Topic for Initial Research Articles (ungraded)**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2

6. Sunday (September 21st) -- Reading an Academic Article, Part II

To be Read for Class:

- Milgram, Stanley (1965). "Some Conditions of Obedience and Disobedience of Authority." *Human Relations*. Vol 18, No 57.
- Blass, Thomas (1999). "The Milgram Paradigm After 35 Years: Some Things We Know about Obedience to Authority." *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*. Vol 29, No 5.

In Class:

- Group discussion on critical analysis assignment
- From topics to questions; from broad questions to focused questions
- **DUE: Short Essay 2 Critical Analysis of an Academic Article**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2, 4

WEEK 4

7. Friday (September 26th) -- Research Methods, Part I: What is Method, Ethnography

To be Read for Class:

- Spradley, James (1979). *The Ethnographic Interview*. New York: Holt, Reinhart, and Winston. Selections (TBD).
- Murphy, Elizabeth and Robert Dingwall (2001). "The Ethics of Ethnography" in *The Handbook of Ethnography*, Paul Atkinson, et al eds. New York: Sage. Selections (TBD).

In Class:

- What are academic disciplines?
- What is method?
- Discussion of the problems and practice of ethnography
- Ethical considerations in research
- First background research articles arrive

Progress on Course Objectives: 1

8. Sunday (September 28th) -- Research Methods, Part II: The Scientific Method

To be Read for Class:

- Kuhn, Thomas (1996). *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*. Third Edition. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press. Selections (TBD).
- Khaldun (2004). "Introduction" in *The Muqaddimah: An Introduction to History*, NJ Dawood, ed. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, pp. 1-32.

In Class:

- Overview of the scientific method
- Discussion of inductive and deductive reasoning
- Qualitative versus quantitative evidence
- Continued discussion of the research methods employed by different disciplines
- Return Short Essay 2 graded

Progress on Course Objectives: 1

WEEK 5

9. Friday (October 3rd) -- Workshopping Research Proposals

In Class:

- Continued discussion of research methods
- Peer review of progress on research proposals
- One-on-one meetings to refine the research question
- Mid-Semester Instructor Evaluations
- Additional research articles begin arriving

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

10. Sunday (October 5th) -- Sharing Project Proposals

In Class:

- Short oral presentations of project proposals
- Mid-Semester Instructor Evaluations
- (Possible Guest Lecture presentation, TBD)
- Additional research articles begin arriving
- **DUE: Project Proposal**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4, 5

WEEK 6

11. Friday (October 10th) -- Constructing a Logical Argument (*may be switched with class 12)

To be Read for Class:

- Becker, Howard S (1998). *Tricks of the Trade: How to Think About your Research While You're Doing It*. Chicago, University of Chicago Press, chapter 5, pages 146-164.
- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 114-135.

In Class:

- Beginning to answer a research question
- Formulating a thesis statement
- Constructing a logical argument
- Additional research articles begin arriving

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 3

12. Sunday (October 12th) -- Using Sources (*may be switched with class 11)

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 90-107 and 285-288.

In Class:

- Distinctions between summarizing, paraphrasing and quoting
- Citation styles
- Exercise on using sources and speedy reading
- Discussion of plagiarism and academic integrity
- Additional research articles begin arriving
- Return graded Project Proposal
- Assign Annotated Bibliography

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2

WEEK 7

13. Friday (October 17th) -- Using Evidence

To Be Read For Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 138-149.

In Class:

- Discussion of evidence and reasons
- Individual and group work on constructing evidence and reasons for the final paper

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2, 4

14. Sunday (October 19th) -- Guest Lectures

In Class:

- Guest Lecture presentations (TBD)
- Assign Final Paper Outline

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 3, 4

WEEK 8

15. Friday (October 24th) -- Outlining, Planning, and Drafting

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 185-221.

In Class:

- Individual and group work on outlining, planning and drafting
- Thesis statement and research question revision
- One-on-one discussion of Annotated Bibliography
- Assign Final Paper Outline
- **DUE: Annotated Bibliography** (checked in class and immediately returned)

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 3, 4

16. Sunday (October 26th) -- Counter Arguments

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 151-164.
- Additional reading (TBD)

In Class:

- Group exercise identifying and responding to counter arguments
- Continued work with source materials

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 3, 4

WEEK 9

17. Friday (October 31st) -- Introducing and Concluding

To be Read for Class:

- Booth, Colomb and Williams (2003), pages 222-238.

In Class:

- In-class reading and evaluation of example introductions (TBD)
- In-class drafting of introductions

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

18. Sunday (November 2nd) -- Writing for Clarity

To be Read for Class:

- Williams, Joseph M. and Gregory G Colomb (2010). *Style: Lessons in Clarity and Grace*. Boston: Longman, pages 2-9 and 28-65.
- Sword, Helen (2012). *Stylish Academic Writing*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, chapter 5.

In Class:

- Individual and group work on rough drafts
- Focused revision of introductions from Friday
- Identifying and solving writing bottlenecks
- One-on-one work with paper outlines
- **DUE: Final Paper Outline** (checked in class and immediately returned)

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

WEEK 10

19. Friday (November 7th) -- Guest Lectures

In Class:

- Guest Lecture presentations (TBD)
- **DUE: Final Paper Draft**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5

20. Sunday (November 9th) -- Guest Lectures

In Class:

- Guest Lecture presentations (Kony Kim, law and political science; other TBD)

Progress on Course Objectives: 1

WEEK 11

21. Friday (November 14th) -- Writing and Revising for Concision

To be Read for Class:

- Williams, Joseph M. and Gregory G Colomb (2010). *Style: Lessons in Clarity and Grace*. Boston: Longman, pages 66-81.

In Class:

- In-class discussion and revision workshop
- What is the revision process? How to go about editing and revising?
- Accepting constructive criticism
- Return graded and commented rough drafts

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 4

22. Sunday (November 16th) -- Giving a Strong Presentation

**** Note: The Withdrawal deadline is Wednesday, November 19th ****

To be Read for Class:

- Ghez, Andrea (July 2009). "The Hunt for a Supermassive Black Hole." TED Talk.
- Anderson, Chris (June 2013). "How to Give a Killer Presentation." *The Harvard Business Review*.

In Class:

- In-class discussion and revision workshop
- Discussion of upcoming presentations
- Assign Final Presentation
- Return the remainder of the graded and commented rough drafts

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 5

WEEK 12

23. Friday (November 21st)

In Class:

- In-Class Presentations of Final Papers, Day 1

Progress on Course Objectives: 5

24. Sunday (November 23rd)

In Class:

- In-Class Presentations of Final Papers, Day 2

Progress on Course Objectives: 5

WEEK 13

25. Friday (November 28th) -- NO CLASS

26. Sunday (November 30th) -- Final Class Wrap-Up

In Class:

- Collective reflections on the research process
- Short lecture on research funding and dissemination
- Guest Lecture: Adriane Fresh, "Political and Economic Institutions"
- **DUE: Final Paper**

Progress on Course Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5